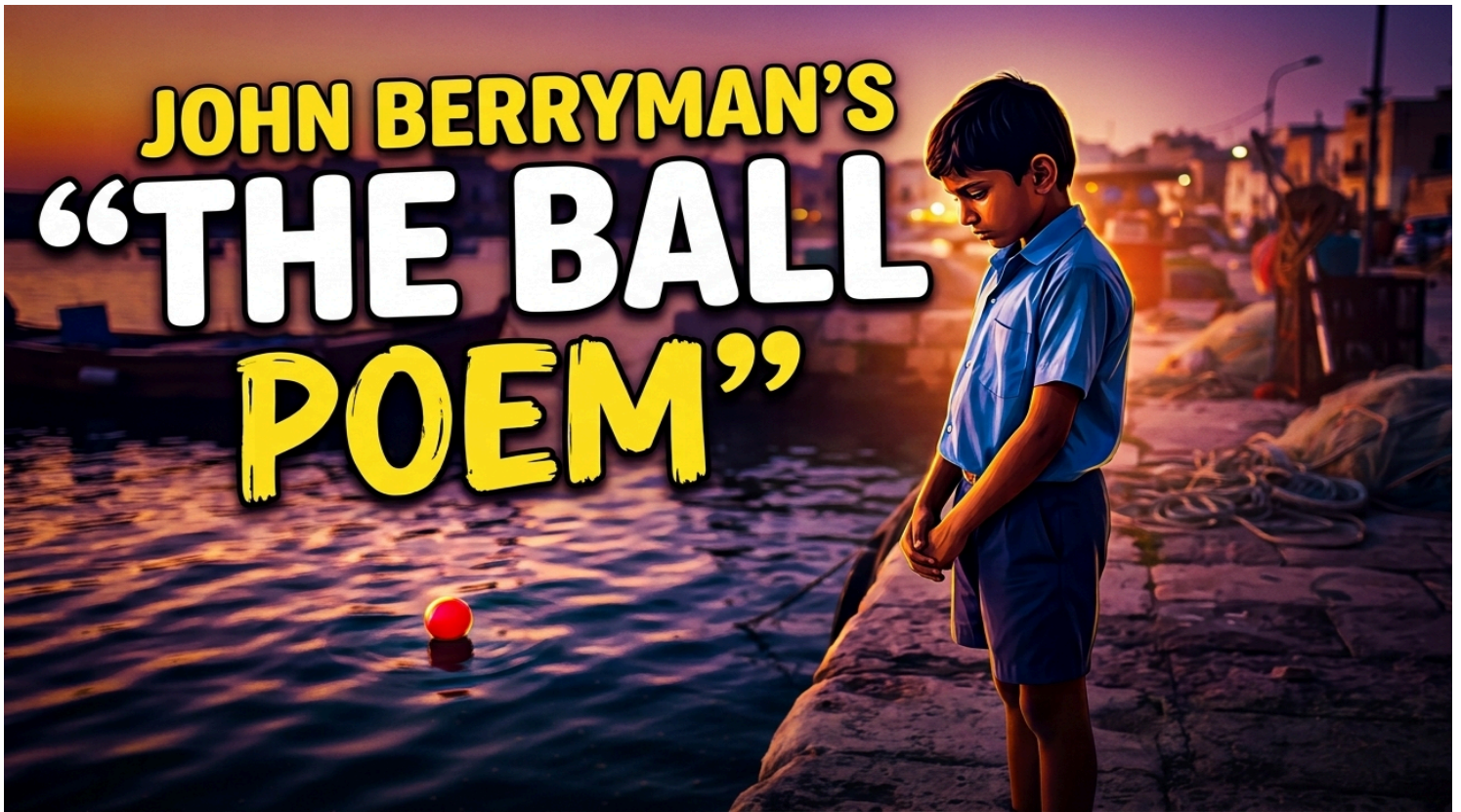


❖“The Ball Poem” by John Berryman❖



📖 Summary

A boy loses his ball in the water. He is very upset. The ball is cheap but it is important to him because he has many memories with it. Through this loss, he learns his first lesson of responsibility and loss in a world of possessions. He learns that money cannot buy back memories and he has to learn how to stand up after losing something dear.

এজন ল'ৰাই পানীত বল হেৰুৱাইছে। বৰ বেয়া লাগিছে সি। বলটো সস্তীয়া যদিও তেওঁৰ বাবে ই গুৰুত্বপূৰ্ণ কাৰণ ইয়াৰ লগত তেওঁৰ বহু স্মৃতি আছে। এই ক্ষতিৰ জৰিয়তে তেওঁ সম্পত্তিৰ জগতখনত দায়িত্ব আৰু ক্ষতিৰ প্ৰথম পাঠ শিকে। সি শিকে যে টকাই স্মৃতি ঘূৰাই কিনিব নোৱাৰে আৰু প্ৰিয় কিবা এটা হেৰুৱাই থিয় হ'বলৈ শিকিব লাগে।

□ 6 Important Word Meanings | The Ball Poem: □

1. Merrily – Happily, in a cheerful way
2. Rigid – Stiff, unable to move
3. Intrude – To enter without being invited / to disturb
4. Dime – A coin of 10 cents (USA) / a small amount of money
5. Possessions – Things that we own
6. Epistemology – Study of the nature of knowledge / Understanding

1. Why is the boy so upset about losing his ball?

Ans: The ball was very dear to him and held all his childhood memories. So he is not upset for the cost of the ball, but for the loss of his childhood.

2. What does the poet mean by "An ultimate shaking grief fixes the boy"?

Ans: It means the boy is completely filled with sadness. He stands rigid, trembling and staring at the harbour where his ball went. This is his first deep feeling of loss.

3. Why does a dime and another ball become worthless for the boy?

Ans: Because no amount of money can buy back the memories associated with the old ball. A new ball will not be the same, so it is worthless to him.

4. What does the poet mean by "In a world of possessions"?

Ans: It means we live in a materialistic world where we own things. We get attached to them and then we have to learn that they can be lost.

5. What is "the epistemology of loss" the boy is learning?

Ans: It means the boy is learning the nature and meaning of loss. He is learning how to deal with losing something dear in life.

6. What lesson does the boy learn from losing the ball?

Ans: He learns his first responsibility – that losses are a part of life, balls will be lost, money is external and cannot bring back everything, and he must learn to stand up and move on.

◆◆◆Thinking about the Poem◆◆◆

1. Why does the poet say, "I would not intrude on him"? Why doesn't he offer him money to buy another ball?

Ans: The poet says "I would not intrude on him" because the boy is deeply sad and alone with his grief. This is his first experience of loss, and he needs time to feel it and understand it by himself. If the poet disturbs him, he will not learn the lesson of loss.

He doesn't offer him money to buy another ball because:

1. Money cannot buy back the old memories associated with that ball.
2. The boy needs to learn that money is external and cannot replace everything.
3. Losing is a part of life and he has to learn to stand up with that loss.

2. "... staring down/All his young days into the harbour where/His ball went ..." Do you think the boy has had the ball for a long time? Is it linked to the memories of days when he played with it?

Ans: Yes, the boy has had the ball for a long time. The phrase "All his young days" shows that the ball holds all his childhood memories. When he stares into the harbour, he is not just seeing his ball going away, but his whole childhood flashing before him.

Yes, the ball is fully linked to his memories. He must have played with it for many years, so losing it means losing a part of his past.

3. What does "in the world of possessions" mean?

Ans: "In the world of possessions" means that this world is full of material things that we own and get attached to. We buy things, we love them, but we also lose them. The boy is now learning this truth – that in this material world, we have to face loss and learn to live with it.

4. Do you think the boy has lost anything earlier? Pick out the words that suggest the answer.

Ans: No, the boy has not lost anything earlier. This is his first experience of loss.

The words that suggest this are:

- "He senses first responsibility"
- "He is learning, well behind his desperate eyes, The epistemology of loss, how to stand up"

These lines show he is feeling loss for the first time and is learning how to deal with it.

5. What does the poet say the boy is learning from the loss of the ball? Try to explain this in your own words.

Ans: The boy is learning the biggest lesson of life – how to deal with loss.

In my own words, he is learning that:

1. Many things will be lost in life.
2. Money cannot buy everything back.
3. We must learn to stand up and be strong even after losing something dear.

6. Have you ever lost something you liked very much? Write a paragraph describing how you felt then, and saying whether and how you got over your loss.

Ans: Yes, I once lost my favourite watch which was gifted by my grandfather. I had it for three years and I wore it every day. One day I lost it on the playground while playing. I felt very sad and guilty, just like the boy in the poem. I kept searching for it everywhere and stared at the place where I lost it. For a few days I felt empty. Slowly, I understood that the watch is gone and I cannot get it back. I learned to live with that loss, but I still keep its memory.
